UNANI MEDICINE

A Heritage of Healing, A Future of Holistic Healthcare for the Nation and Beyond

The Unani System of Medicine, with its rich historical roots and time-tested treatments, has been an integral part of India's healthcare landscape for centuries. As the world increasingly turns towards traditional medicine systems for holistic health solutions, India has taken a leadership role in promoting Unani Medicine. At the forefront of this movement is the Central Council for Research in Unani Medicine (CCRUM), under the visionary leadership of Dr. N. Zaheer Ahmed. In this exclusive interview, Dr. Ahmed sheds light on CCRUM's achievements, strategic vision, and the future of Unani Medicine in India and beyond:



Dr. N. Zaheer Ahmed
Director General
Central Council for Research in Unani Medicine (CCRUM)

The CCRUM has made significant strides in various research domains. Could you elaborate on the key research areas and how they contribute to the advancement of Unani Medicine?

The CCRUM, an apex research establishment under the Ministry of Ayush, has made significant strides in advancing Unani Medicine through diverse research initiatives.

Clinical Research has been pivotal, with over 130 randomized trials and numerous projects validating Unani drugs for chronic diseases like vitiligo, psoriasis, hepatitis, and asthma. The CCRUM is also developing new drugs for emerging diseases, enhancing dosage forms for diabetes, and exploring the immuno-modulatory effects of Unani treatments.

Fundamental Research has aligned Unani principles with modern science through 30 studies, bridging traditional theories with genetic and biochemical insights.

In **Preclinical Research**, the CCRUM has conducted safety and toxicology studies on 115 single drugs and coded formulations, alongside pharmacological studies on 70 Unani formulations. This ensures that the drugs are safe and effective for public use.

Literary Research reflects the CCRUM's dedication to preserving the rich heritage of Unani Medicine. This includes the translation of 66 volumes of classical texts, the compilation of 22 books, the creation of a vast database of manuscripts, and the reprinting of over 70 rare classical books.

Drug Standardization has established quality standards for 338 single and 200 compound drugs, ensuring consistent efficacy.

Lastly, through **Survey and Cultivation of Medicinal Plants**, the CCRUM has collected over 1 lakh plant specimens, cultivated rare species, and documented traditional medicinal knowledge, contributing to the conservation of medicinal biodiversity. These efforts collectively strengthen the scientific foundation and global relevance of Unani Medicine.

Moreover, the CCRUM's success is deeply rooted in its research collaborations and partnerships. By joining forces with national and international research institutions, universities, and healthcare organizations, it broadens its research capabilities and impact. These partnerships facilitate knowledge exchange, access to cutting-edge technologies, and help the CCRUM tackle research problems and health challenges, positioning Unani Medicine as a credible and complementary healthcare system on the world stage.

How does CCRUM integrate traditional Unani practices with modern scientific approaches, particularly in the realm of drug standardization and clinical research?

The integration of traditional practices with modern scientific methodologies is at the heart of our research agenda. To ensure the highest standards of safety and efficacy, we use state-of-the-art technologies in drug standardization and clinical research. In drug standardization, our approach involves developing standard operating procedures (SOPs) and pharmacopeial standards that are on par with global benchmarks. This involves modern analytical techniques, including phytochemical analysis and molecular profiling.

In clinical research, the CCRUM applies modern scientific rigor to validate the therapeutic benefits of Unani treatments. The studies at the CCRUM utilize contemporary research methodologies, such as randomized controlled trials and evidence-based assessments, while preserving the holistic and individualized approach characteristic of Unani medicine. The CCRUM also collaborate with premier scientific institutes and organizations for integrative research. By merging traditional knowledge with modern science, the CCRUM not only enhances the credibility and effectiveness of Unani Medicine but also ensures its integration into the broader healthcare system.

Can you discuss CCRUM's role in promoting Unani Medicine at the grassroots level, particularly through healthcare services and community outreach programs?

Reaching the grassroots is a critical component of our mission. Unani Medicine has always been a people's medicine, accessible and affordable, and we aim to keep it that way. Through our network of 23 healthcare centers across the country, we provide comprehensive Unani healthcare services to diverse communities. Under the financial patronage and guidance of the Ministry of Ayush, we operate Unani clinics and health centers across India, offering free treatment and raising awareness of Unani practices. The CCRUM also conducts health camps, school health programs, and public health initiatives like Mobile Health Programme under Scheduled Caste Sub-Plan and Tribal Sub-Plan, ensuring that Unani Medicine reaches underserved populations in rural areas and urban slums at their doorsteps and is integrated into community health practices. These efforts strengthen Unani's role in primary healthcare and public health education

What is your strategic vision for the future of Unani Medicine in India, particularly in the context of global health challenges?

My strategic vision for CCRUM and Unani Medicine is deeply aligned with our nation's broader healthcare goals and the global health challenges we face today. Looking ahead, we aim to further strengthen our research capabilities, particularly in the areas of drug development, clinical research, and digital health initiatives. By leveraging digital platforms and telemedicine, we plan to bring Unani healthcare to even the most remote areas. The focus will also be on increasing the global reach of Unani Medicine through international collaborations. By aligning Unani practices with contemporary science, the goal is to position Unani Medicine as a key player in addressing lifestyle disorders, chronic diseases, and public health crises on a global scale.